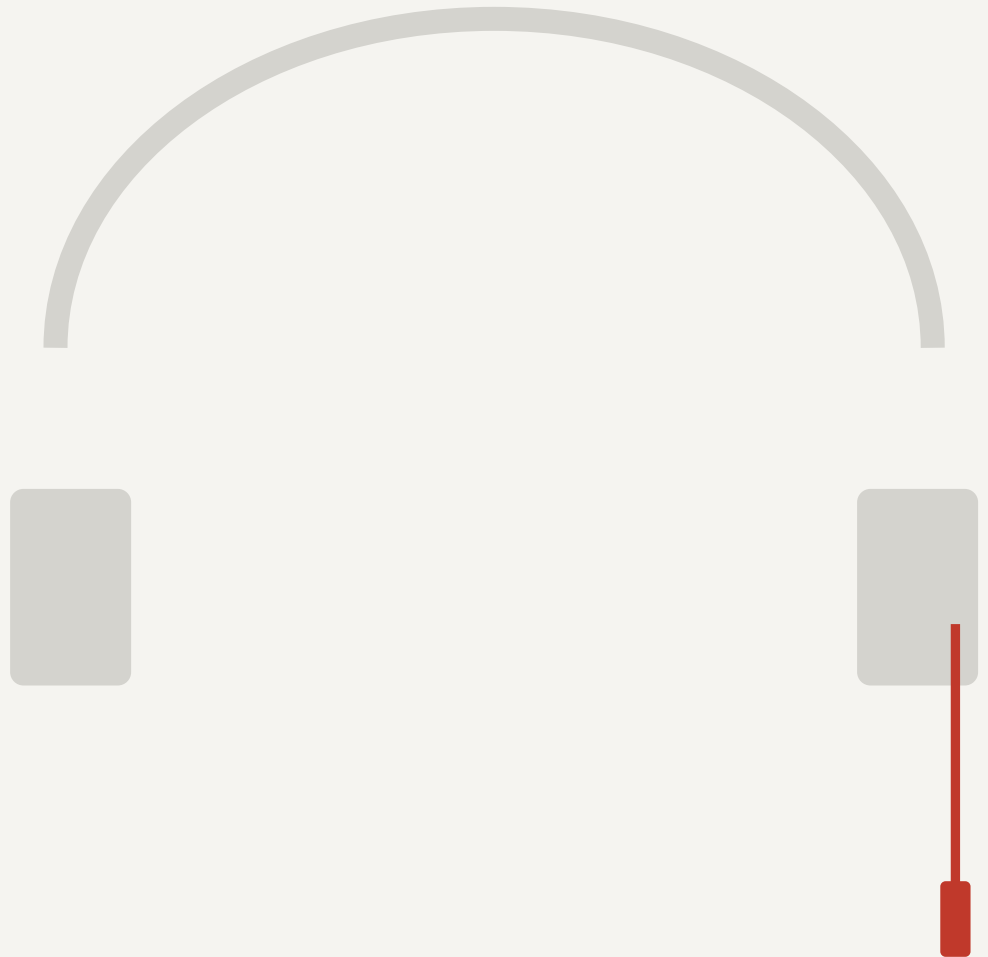


Wired is Back

How the headphone everyone declared dead
became the business story of the decade

May 2026



Everyone declared wired dead

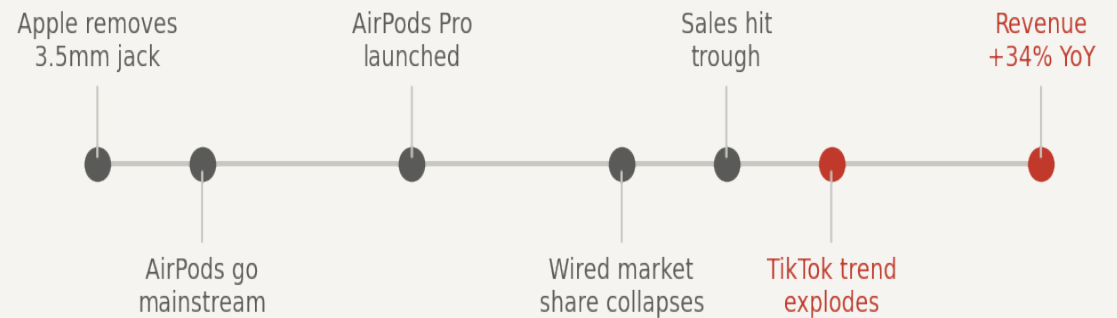
Apple removed the headphone jack in 2016. The eulogies wrote themselves.

"The headphone jack is an ancient, cumbersome standard. It had to go."

— Tech press, 2016

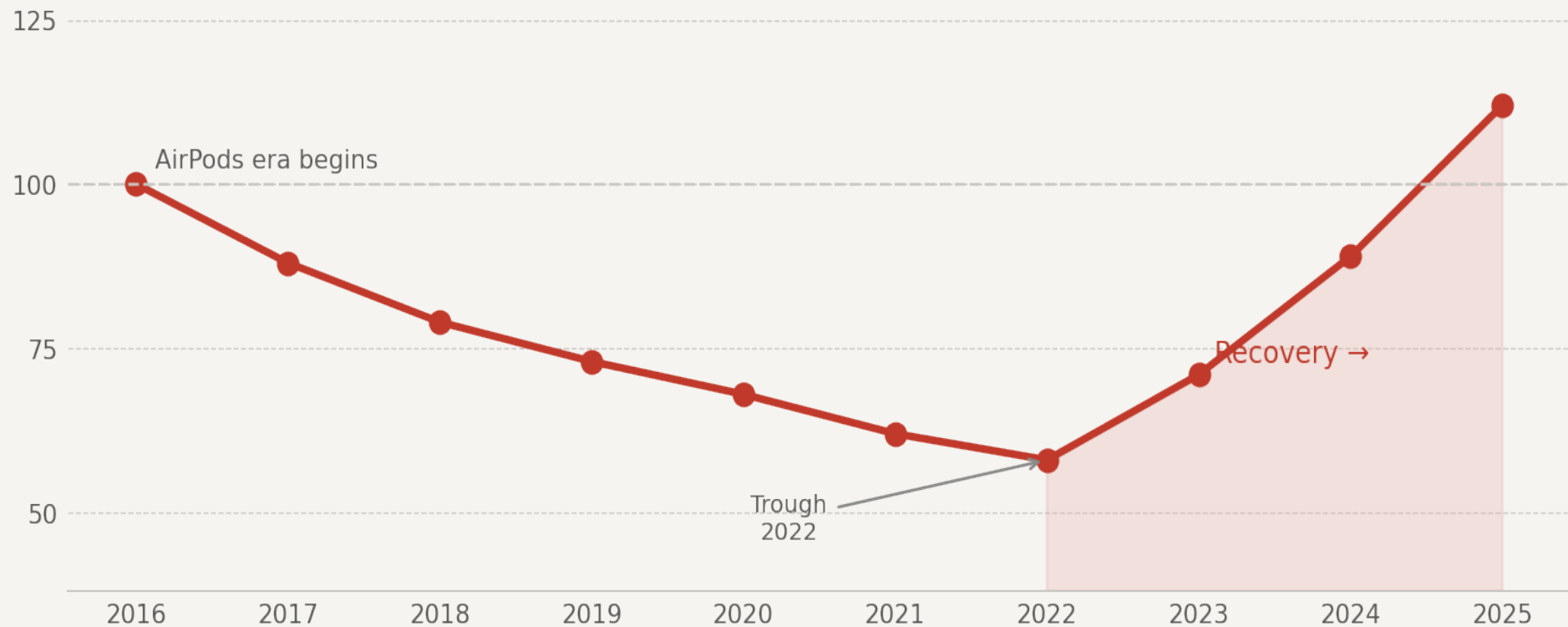
"Wireless is the future. Cables are a relic of analogue thinking."

— Industry analyst, 2019



Sales fell. Then they didn't.

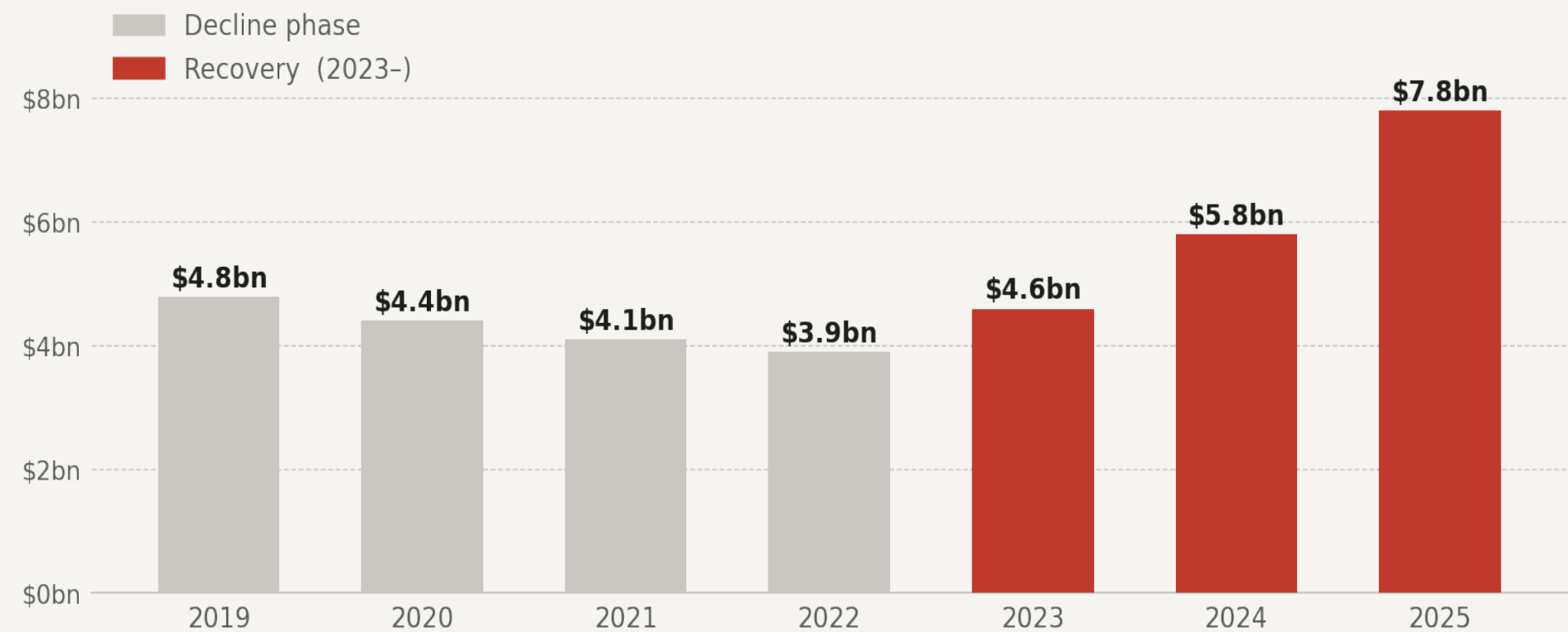
Global wired headphone unit shipments · indexed, 2016 = 100



NB: Index rebased to 2016 = 100. Includes in-ear, on-ear and over-ear wired segments.

Revenue told a different story

Global wired headphone market revenue · \$bn



2025 includes preliminary estimates from Q3 actuals + Q4 consensus.

Four reasons it came back

Not nostalgia. Economics, culture, physics and fatigue.

Gen Z chose the cable

TikTok's 'clean girl' aesthetic made wired headphones a fashion statement. #wiredheadphones hit 2.4 billion views by 2025.

Audio physics don't lie

Lossless audio, no Bluetooth codec compression, zero latency. A \$30 wired pair outperforms many \$200 wireless options.

Battery anxiety is real

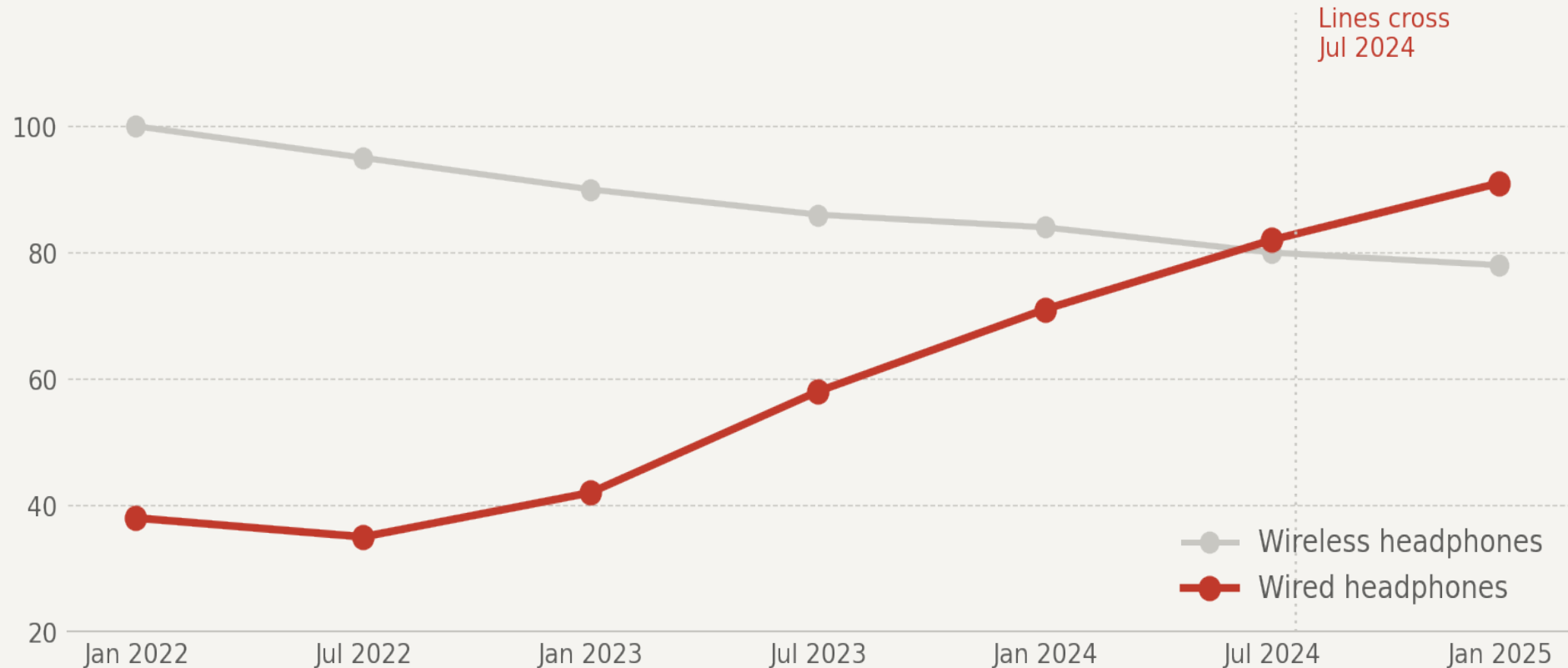
Consumers juggle an average of 3 wireless devices that need charging. One less battery to manage genuinely matters.

Price collapse changed the calculus

Chinese manufacturers brought audiophile-grade drivers into the \$15–\$30 range — a price point wireless cannot match.

TikTok did what no ad campaign could

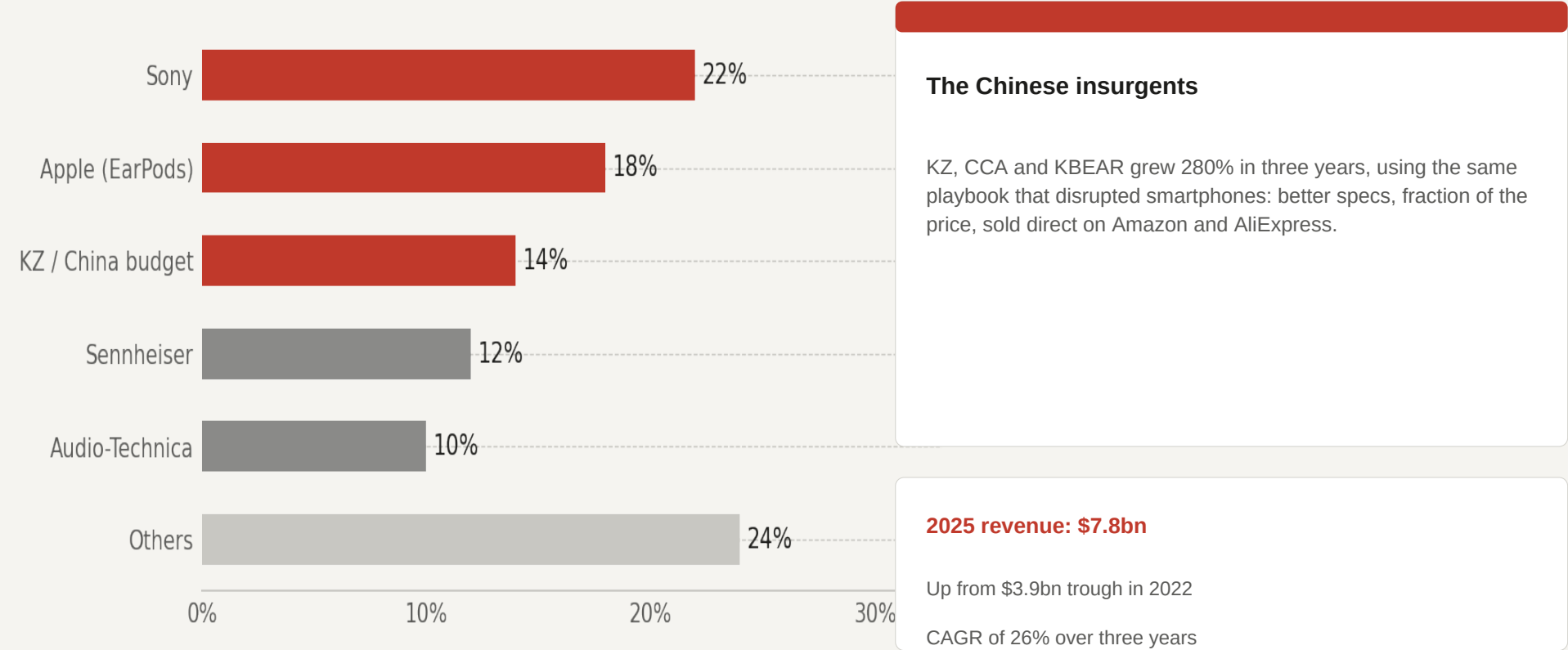
Google Trends search interest: 'wired headphones' vs 'wireless headphones' · 100 = peak



NB: Google Trends search interest index, rebased. Represents relative interest, not absolute volume.

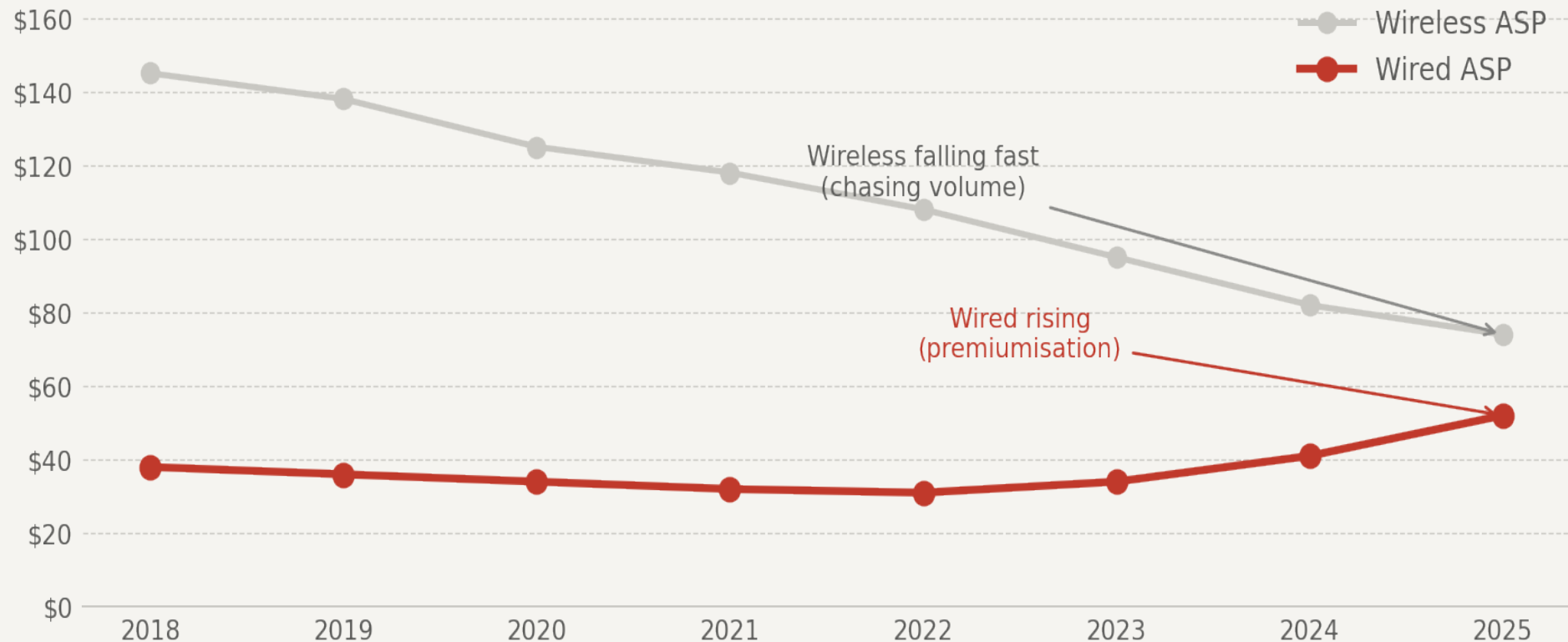
Old players and new winners

Wired headphone market share by revenue · 2025 estimate



Price elasticity did the heavy lifting

Average selling price: wired vs wireless headphones · \$USD



As wireless chases volume at low price points, wired moves up-market. The gap closes. The story inverts.

Is this a trend or a transformation?

What wired headphones really tell us about consumer tech

● **Not everything wireless stays wireless**

Convenience beats quality — until quality matters more than convenience. The equilibrium shifts when the gap closes.

● **Hardware fashion cycles are real**

Gen Z wearing cables is Gen X wearing denim jackets. Retrotech is a proven consumer pattern. Gen Alpha is already watching.

● **Chinese manufacturing disrupts every market eventually**

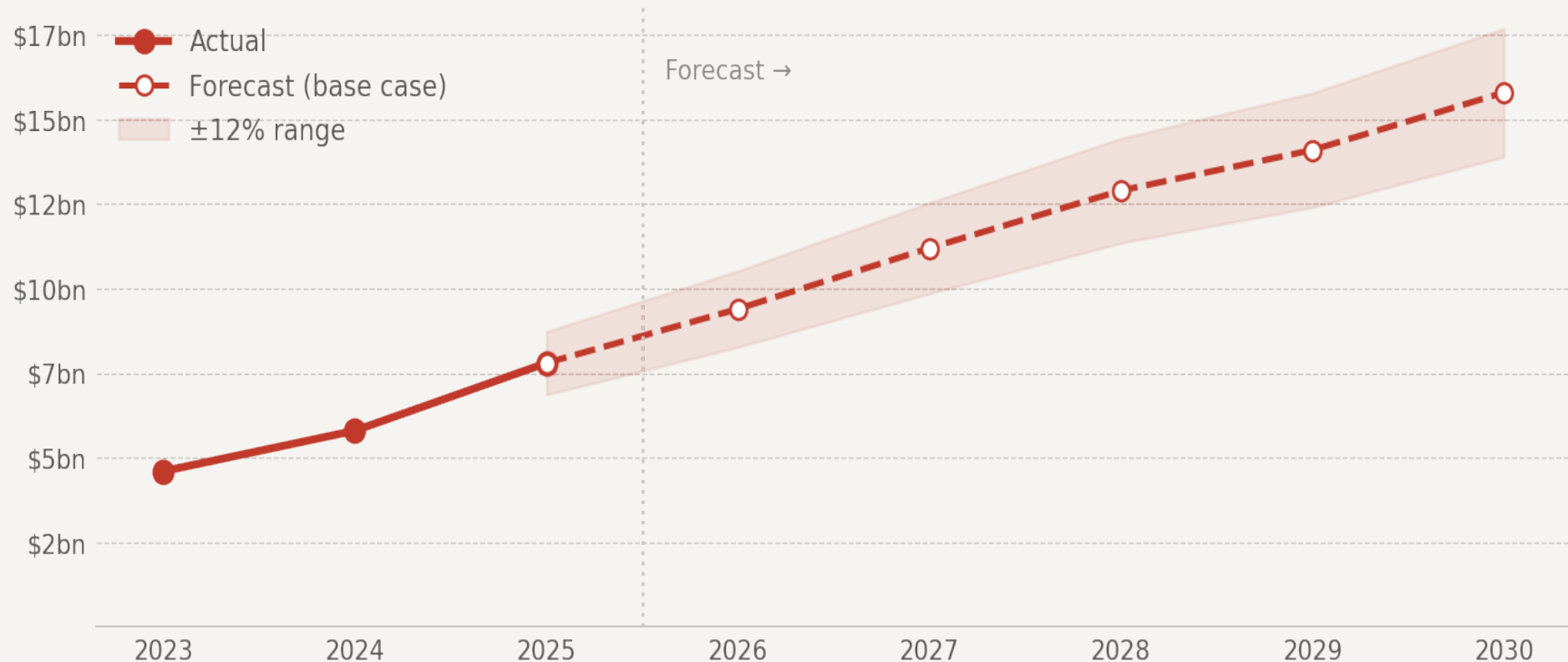
When \$15 buys audiophile-grade wired sound, the economics of every wireless competitor change. This has happened before.

● **Battery fatigue is a structural problem, not a mood**

Every wireless device is a device that dies. The average consumer now charges 5+ devices a day. One less matters.

Where does this go?

Global wired headphone market revenue forecast · \$bn



Base case assumes continued premiumisation + Gen Z cohort maturing into higher-spend bracket. Bear/bull cases differ by ±12%.

**“The best interface
is one you don’t have
to charge.”**

— Wired headphone fan, Reddit, 2023

The jack is back. The question is whether this
is a cycle or a permanent re-evaluation of
what ‘better’ means in consumer hardware.

Wired is Back

The comeback nobody in Silicon Valley predicted

Data sources

- IDC Worldwide Wired Audio Tracker
- Grand View Research Audio Equipment Market Analysis
- Google Trends (search interest index)
- GfK Point-of-Sale Data
- CTA (Consumer Technology Association) Shipment Data
- Counterpoint Research Global TWS & Wired Headphone Report
- Statista Consumer Electronics Market Outlook
- Sensor Tower Mobile App Intelligence
- Bloomberg Intelligence Consumer Tech